

Reflection on My Interview with Engr. Queen Morales

In Partial Fulfilment of
the requirements in Computer Engineering as a Discipline

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CPE 008 - Computer Engineering as a Discipline

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Engr. Ji Han Gang

Introduction

As part of our CPE-008 - Computer Engineering as a Discipline course, our group conducted an interview with Engr. Queen Morales to learn about her experiences as an alumna and her journey after graduation. The interview aimed to explore her career journey, the challenges she encountered, and the lessons she learned throughout her career as a computer engineer. Through this discussion, we hoped to gain valuable insights and advice that could help us prepare for our future careers as computer engineering students.

Summary of the Interview

During our interview with Queen Morales, she shared her experiences as a computer engineering graduate from the Polytechnic University of the Philippines in 2002. After graduating, she joined Accenture, where she has worked for 22 years and is now a Quality Engineering (QE) leader based in Chicago, Illinois. She explained that her college journey was not easy because her family struggled financially. There were times when she could not afford the materials required for her subjects and had to borrow from her classmates. Despite these difficulties, she continued her studies because her family motivated her to keep going. She also talked about the challenges she faced when she first started working, especially the difference between college assignments and actual workplace responsibilities. According to her, professional work involves stricter deadlines and collaboration with different teams. One statement that stood out to us was, "Your attitude will determine your altitude." She explained that we do not always have to be the smartest person in the room, but we should be willing to learn and accept that we still have a lot to improve.

Another important part of the interview was her advice for computer engineering students who are preparing for their future careers. She encouraged us to explore and learn more things, such as Python, artificial intelligence, and cloud computing, because these are increasingly relevant in the industry. She also recommended that students build their portfolios as early as possible through simple projects, such as creating applications or websites. As she said, "You start small and start now." This advice is helpful to us because we are still first-year students and are just beginning to develop our technical skills. She also reminded us not to compare our progress with others and not to be afraid of making mistakes. When we asked about the importance of academic performance, she explained that "the grades are important, but they really don’t define you.” She believes that grades alone cannot fully measure a person’s abilities or potential to succeed. This part of the interview made us realize that although doing well in school matters, we should also focus on gaining practical experience and improving ourselves. Overall, her experience gave us a better understanding of what we may face after graduation and how we can start preparing for our future careers while we are still in college.

Personal Reflection

Ma. Andrea Cervantes

What struck me most was the fact that Engr. Morales didn't have to jump from job to job to find what suited her best. Her first company simply relocated her to Chicago to learn, and she grew there, reaching the position she's in now. Even then, during her college years, she wasn't the student who had the money to afford all that she needed. She had questioned her decision of pursuing computer engineering a couple times, but with her family in mind, she pushed through and has led a fulfilling life and career since then. Her decision to pursue computer engineering stemmed from a random comment from her aunt, "Hey, you're good in math." It's a lot similar to the comments I'd hear from my parents and, sometimes, close teachers. I learned, from her words, "Your attitude determines your altitude." You don't need to be the smartest person in the room; maintain humility and a willingness to learn, and it should open more opportunities.

In college, as Engr. Morales mentioned, there is a greater emphasis on individual responsibility and discipline; they do their homework, they study for the exams, and they do their projects. Whether they pass or fail depends on their solo work. In the workplace, it's more about collaboration, and the outcome of the project relies on strict deadlines and the effectiveness of the team. In college, the consequences of a coding error or a missed assignment are pretty straightforward: a bad grade. At work, it could potentially bring about losses.

She mentioned that she nearly wasn't able to get into computer engineering at PUP due to her grades. Hearing that made me look back on my own. I may have had decent grades, enough to gain admission to all colleges I applied to, but my current grades haven't been so good. Her story encouraged me to not fear mistakes or failure but to view setbacks as opportunities to learn and build resilience. As Engr. Morales pointed out, while academic grades are important, they do not measure my full potential, curiosity, creativity, or leadership. Engr. Morales also mentioned immersing herself into her studies because she was beginning to feel left behind by her peers, a feeling I can relate to. I, for one, never had any deep connection or interest in computers, technology, and the like, and instead wanted to pursue something creative. Finding myself in this path made me think twice about my suitability, especially since nearly everyone I knew on the same path chose what they knew best. Hearing her view on that made me reflect on how I kept comparing myself to others. Their successes felt sweeter to see than what I had accomplished myself, but after the interview, I began making an effort to focus on my personal growth rather than comparing my progress with that of others.

Timothy Gabriel Enclona

22 years in the company and the job of Engr. Morales had made me realize that there is a different set of resources and teams. The professional setting is vastly different compared to a college setting. There is a documentation process, and deadlines for these projects are very damaging when the team has reasons for being unable to complete it. When a team member cannot do their part, a person has to step up in their place despite the technical skills that are out

of their expertise. Additionally, “Don’t compare" and “Don’t be afraid to ask questions" are two quotes that struck me and affected me the most, considering how much I did not want to seem incompetent compared to the others. Though, to add onto it, others may have different journeys to get to where they are, and what also struck me is the reasons to keep going. At first, it was to complete her studies, and now she has a family to support.

I view my career goals a little differently, and to line up with my academic goals, small steps have to be taken seriously with time. Obviously, rushing does not lead to good quality work, and it’s been a far more constant variable in my life. No matter how many times I wanted to review early, I fell into procrastination rather than doing it immediately. Considering the subjects in college, like mathematics, where I tend to have more procrastination, I became more inspired to try. Not just try. Simply practice even if it’s just 1 question a day or more than that, with how this skill in solving carries over to programming as well.

To not compare, to not be afraid, and to not let grades define me. These three have been the core point of my fears. Even if I have been told numerous times, it simply stayed. Now the feelings of these three are different when said by an engineer. I may fail, but that is fine. It shows that I have the willingness to learn and be resilient, to get back up and be better later on. Small steps like small projects for portfolios can also expand, so learning more on other programming languages will be a starting point to apply to my journey. And to apply the advice, I will think first and then slowly direct myself to what steps I can take in order for any wrong turns to be corrected.

Rhianna Avril Manlutac

After the interview with Engr. Morales, I realized that I still have a lot to go through to get to where I want to be. What struck me the most from the interview was about how mathematics, programming, and databases are the most useful subjects from school to her professional life. She said that mathematics helps in logical thinking, which is used to solve problems. I was really surprised when she said that those are the most useful subjects because I am lacking in those areas. Her story greatly impacted me because she was resilient and persevering towards her goals. What stuck to me was how God was a part of her journey, and it was Him that made her who she is today. It greatly motivated me to do well in my studies and also have God by my side. With the knowledge and experiences she shared, it made me reflect on myself and inspired me to strive more.

There were moments that were both inspiring and surprising because I learned that even when you do not have everything, you can still do it even when it is hard. I was really surprised when she told us that her aunt was the one who told her to take computer engineering because she is good at mathematics. Moreover, she talked about how grades are not the measure of your potential; it is your story when applying for jobs, but it is not the whole story because the beginning of your story will start when you work. The advice she gave us that I want to apply in my journey is that it is okay to make mistakes, learn from the mistakes, and have fun while I am still in college. I learned a lot from the interview, and I know that I can use her experiences and advice as a guide for my journey as a computer engineering student.

Matt Francis Pascual

After listening to Engr. Queen Morales shared her experiences. I realized that pursuing a career in computer engineering is not as simple as graduating and finding a job. What stood out to me the most was how she managed to finish her studies despite her family's financial struggles. She mentioned that she sometimes had to borrow materials from her classmates because she could not afford everything she needed. I found her story inspiring because even with those difficulties, she still managed to graduate and eventually become a leader at Accenture in Chicago. Her statement, "Your attitude will determine your altitude," also made me realize that having the right mindset is just as important as having technical knowledge.

As a first-year computer engineering student, I sometimes wonder if the things we learn in college will be enough to prepare us for the actual workplace. During the interview, I learned that professional work is very different from what we experience in school. Engr. Morales explained that employees have to work with different teams and adjust when plans suddenly change. This made me understand why communication is important, especially in a field where people need to work together to complete projects. I also found her advice about building a portfolio helpful because it encouraged me to start creating simple programs and projects instead of waiting until I graduate.

Another lesson I learned from the interview was that grades do not completely determine how successful someone will become. As a student, I sometimes focus too much on academic performance and forget that there are other skills I still need to develop. Her advice about not comparing ourselves to others also made me think about how everyone has their own pace when it comes to learning. Moving forward, I want to become more confident in asking questions and take more opportunities to improve my programming skills. Overall, this interview helped me see computer engineering from a different perspective and reminded me that I still have a lot to learn before entering the industry.

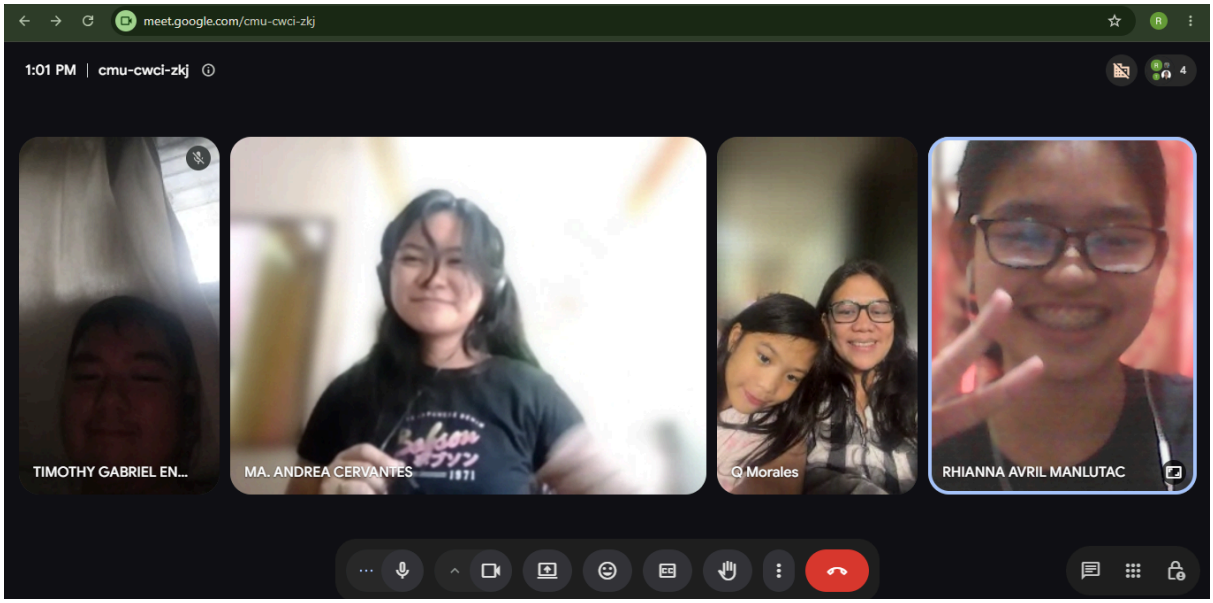
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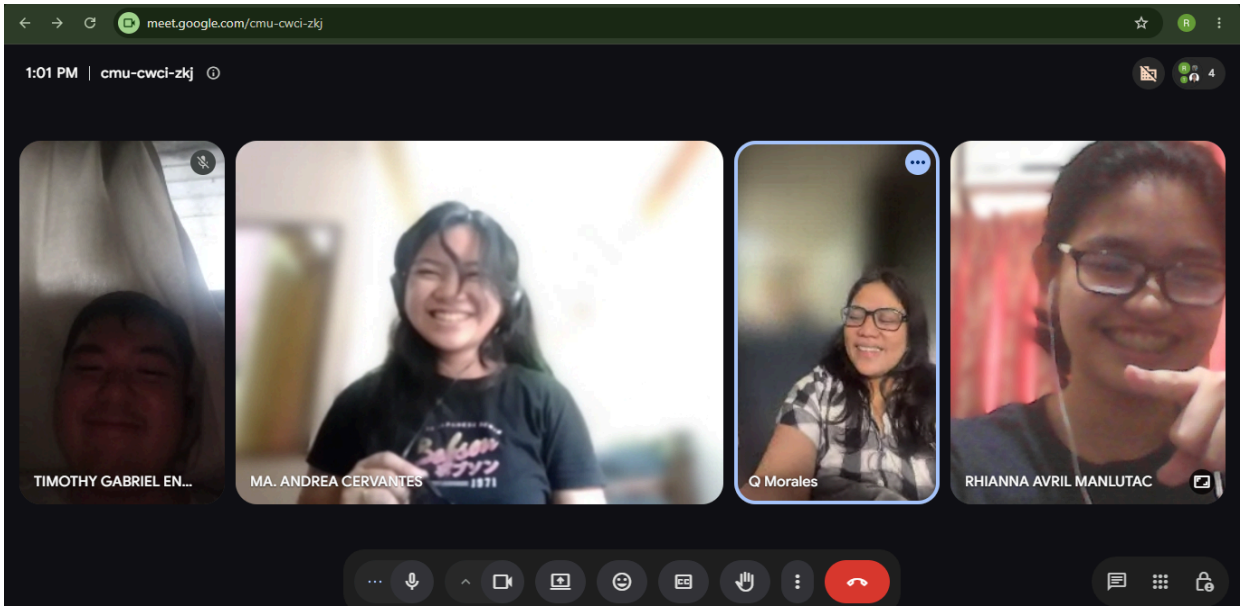
Teamwork in a team is the most important trait that makes an effective team. For many teams and projects to be worked on, members must know their parts and how they can contribute, such as members of testers, members of coders, and members of design. A good leader is essential to provide conflict resolution should there be problems between members where miscommunication, differences of attitudes and personality, and the wrong interpretation of a team member can lead to one. Additionally, to get to the point of having a team and being in a profession, one will build connections through portfolios as resources. From the ground up all the way to having one’s own expertise, where programming languages and math are the essential skills for future engineers. Of the various topics we learned in class, managing better is also another step of the way. This interview has reinforced our understanding of our future profession. From the perspective of an engineer with many years of experience, we are given an insight into the difference inside of the profession and from a college student’s perspective.

Conclusion

Exchanging words with Engr. Morales has expanded our view on computer engineering as first-year students and as prospective computer engineers. Her story has reminded us that setbacks, financial hurdles, and self-doubt do not define ourselves and our potential. But rather, it is our attitude, resilience, and willingness to learn that determines how high we can go. Moving forward, we are inspired to embrace our mistakes, focus on our personal growth, and approach our studies with both dedication and faith. We are deeply grateful for Engr. Morales's time and invaluable wisdom she shared, which will serve as a guiding compass throughout our academic and professional journey. To conclude our interview assignment, we agreed to stay in touch as we eventually transition and settle into the industry.

Appendices




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TIMOTHY GABRIEL EN...
MA. ANDREA CERVANTES
Q Morales
RHIANNA AVRIL MANLUTAC

TIP COMPUTER ENGINEERING
QUEZON CITY

October 21, 2026

Dear **Engr. MORALES,**

Good day!

We are currently enrolled in CPE 008 – Computer Engineering as a Discipline under the supervision of Engr. Ji Han Gang at the Technological Institute of the Philippines, Quezon City.

As part of the course requirements, we are tasked to conduct an interview with an alumni Computer Engineer or a professional working in a computer engineering–related field. The goal of this activity is to gain a deeper understanding of the real-world applications of the discipline, the current trends in the industry, and the professional experiences that shape the practice of computer engineering today.

With this, we would like to formally request your permission to conduct a short interview at your most convenient time and platform.

We would be very grateful for your time and insights, which will greatly help us in our understanding of the field and in our professional growth as future Computer Engineers.

Thank you very much for your kind consideration. We look forward to your positive response.

Respectfully yours,

Ma. Andrea Cervantes
Timothy Gabriel Enclona
Rhianna Avril Manlutac
Matt Francis Pascual

Noted by:

10-21-26

ENGR. JI HAN C. GANG
Instructor, CPE008 – Computer Engineering as a Discipline